

ANI



AFP

MAHARASHTRA

FAULT LINES RESURFACE

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VIOLENT REACTION (Top) Hindu right-wing activists protesting in Nagpur; vehicles set on fire during riots later in the day, Mar. 17

On March 17, a group of Hindu right-wing activists gathered at the old Mahal neighbourhood in Nagpur to demand the demolition of Mughal emperor Aurangzeb's tomb in Khultabad in Maharashtra. Similar protests were taking place across the state. But soon rumours of protesters burning a fabric with religious inscriptions triggered violence in various pockets of Nagpur, leaving 33 people injured. The present spell of violence has exposed deep fissures across the state's socio-political landscape. Reigniting the whole controversy around the Mughal emperor and his antagonistic interface with Maratha history is a Hindi film and political reactions to it.

HOW DID THE ROW ERUPT?

Chhaava, a biopic on Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj, elder son of the Maratha empire founder Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, was released on February 14. It details how a 31-year-old Sambhaji was brutally tortured and killed on Aurangzeb's orders in 1689. At a time when the spotlight was on the Mughal emperor's absolutist ways, Abu Azmi, Samajwadi Party MLA from Mumbai, called him a "good administrator". Not only was Azmi suspended from the state assembly for the rest of the budget session on March 5, the whole episode also triggered demands by the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) and Bajrang Dal to level Aurangzeb's tomb—a simple grave, devoid of the trappings of the Mughal dynasty—at Khultabad near Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (formerly Aurangabad, a city that had only been rechristened in 2023, in a rhetorical foreshadowing of the present tussle). Soon, Maharashtra ports